

Vatican Paradoxographer: Marvels from a Single Manuscript

eul_aid: kwi

Period: Ἑλληνιστική [Hellenistic](#)

Dialect: Κοινή [Koine](#)

Domain: Ἱστορία [History](#)

Format: Πεζός [Prose](#)

The Vatican Paradoxographer is a modern scholarly designation for the anonymous compiler of a paradoxographical collection preserved in a single manuscript, Vaticanus Graecus 305. No biographical details are known. The compiler is dated to the 2nd century BCE based on the content and the dates of the excerpted sources. Paradoxography was a Hellenistic genre dedicated to cataloging wondrous or paradoxical phenomena from the natural world and history.

The sole work is the Paradoxographus Vaticanus, a compilation of excerpts from earlier authors. Preserved in a 13th-century manuscript, the text includes material derived from figures such as Aristeas of Proconnesus, Isigonus of Nicaea, and the natural philosopher Callimachus. The surviving version is considered a Byzantine epitome of a longer Hellenistic compilation.

The compilation is a key representative of Hellenistic paradoxography, reflecting the era's encyclopedic interest in marvels. It preserves valuable fragments of otherwise lost Hellenistic authors, serving as an indirect source for ancient science, geography, and ethnography. Its transmission in a single manuscript underscores the fragile preservation of such specialized genres.

Works (1)

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